



THE ASHANTI KINGDOM



The Ashanti kingdom

The Ashanti kingdom flourished for 200 years after its emergence in the 17th century, in what is now Ghana in West Africa. The Ashanti were a highly organized people; the king had his own civil service, which carried out his commands throughout the country. The Ashanti were also fine warriors, and much of their wealth was based on selling slaves from the prisoners they captured in battle. They had vast quantities of gold which was used to make jewelry and as decoration for musical instruments and weapons. Ashanti goldsmiths were highly skilled in their craft. They used a special method to cast the metal, called the lost-wax technique.

Beautifully made

These royal sandals have flowers of gold sewn onto them.



The item to be cast in gold was modeled in melted beeswax.

The wax was made into thin sheets. These were cut into strips, which were used to make the model.

Clay was molded around the model and a hole made in the clay. As the mold was baked, the wax melted and poured out through the hole. Molten gold was then poured into the space.

When the metal had cooled and hardened, the mold was smashed open. The gold object was taken out and cleaned up.

Ashanti goldsmiths worked gold into all kinds of objects. The handle of this sword was covered in a fine sheet of gold.

